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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1950-1961

Coverage Date: 1950-1961

Place Coverage: Nyae Nyae Region, Namibia And Botswana

Section Title(S)

APPROVED MARRIAGES • DEVIATION FROM THE RULES

Deviations occur frequently, I think, in the fourth category (name-relatives). Two men we met had married women whose names were the same as the men's mothers' names. A man named /Ti!kay married the daughter of another /Ti!kay, and there were other such instances. /Qui said he proposed to do this himself. The girl's family had flatly refused, but he was going to keep on trying. ≠Toma said he would not do this, but he sees some people doing these things. There are not enough women whom one may properly marry, he said with a grin, and he would be in favor of changing the marriage prohibitions among name-relatives so that a man need avoid only ugly women.

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APPROVED MARRIAGES

No marriages are compulsory in !Kung society.

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Marriage is allowed with anyone to whom the incest taboo is not extended. It appeared to me that there were three degrees of approval of marriages: preference, permission, and toleration. Once a marriage has taken place, no differentiation is made.

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The joking relationship is the differentiating factor between the preference and mere permission which the society accords. In preferred marriages the man and women are name-relatives who have had the joking relationship

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before marriage and have applied to each other the terms *!gun!a* and *tūn*. This makes the marriage seem altogether right.

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Kin Relationships

Marriage is permitted between name-relatives who apply the terms *tsu* and *//ga* to each other and avoided joking before marriage, provided the incest taboo is not specifically extended to them; and, in the same way, marriage is permitted between name-relatives who apply to each other the terms *!go*, brother, *!kwi*, sister, or *tsĩ*, younger sibling.

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Marriage is tolerated, though it rarely occurs, as I mentioned before, 262 with persons to whom the name-relationship and the application of kin terms is not extended; that is, persons of other races, persons of other Bushman language groups, or other !Kung outside the Nyae Nyae region.

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